

Whenever I went to a spelling bee, gave a speech, or acted in a school play, he'd leave the office and come watch. Many times he was the only father there."

Now Dave's son and his wife have their own law office in San Francisco. They like to brag a bit about how well their kids swim, dive, play baseball, and do other activities.

"I guess you enjoy watching them every chance you get," I told their father. "You're self-employed and can take the time off."

Dad shook his head. "We never go watch our kids perform. The law practice doesn't give us a chance to leave. We arrange for the maid to drive them where they have to go and pick them up. At night, after we get home, we try to ask them about what they did during the day. But often we get home late, and the kids are already in bed."

I reminded this father how much it had meant to him when *his* father took time out to attend his activities. He shook his head and gave a helpless shrug. "What am I going to do? I'm too busy."

Think about your childhood. If you're like me, you remember every time your dad came to your Little League game, heard your choral group sing, or took you hunting. Yet, how often do you watch your youngsters perform? How often do you and Alex—just the two of you—go fishing? If you're like most parents, you're simply too busy at work.

I don't pretend to tell others how to raise their kids. But in this chapter I assume you have to devote time to your family to have a happy family life. Similarly, I assume moms and dads who spend time with each other have a better chance of staying in love than moms and dads who don't. I assume moms and dads who spend time with their kids have a better chance of being good parents than moms and dads who don't.

Giving your kids money for a new trumpet, ballet class, exercise room, Toyota, and a college education is great. But more than money, your kids need *you*. The great advantage of very early retirement is that you can give yourself—your